Lesson 17

LOVE

"Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good.
His love endures forever."
(Psalm 136:1)

Love: God is love

The Bible is a love story. It tells of God's unfailing love for mankind. Despite man's shortcomings, God loves each and every one of us and He wants us to love Him. He demonstrated His love for us by sending His only Son as a living sacrifice for our sins. In order to be reconciled with God (and to be restored to a full relationship with Him), all we need to do is to repent of our sins and believe in Christ and the One who sent Him. As Christians, we show our love for Christ by obeying His commands, and passing on God's love and Christ's love to our fellow man.

In order to be truly mentally healthy, you must seek God, discover how much He loves you, fall in love with his Son, Jesus Christ, who died for you, confess your sins, and love one another.

Synopsis

God is love.[1] He is the source of all love.[2] We are able to love because God first loved us.[3] He is loving toward all He has made.[4] It

God is love.
(1 John 4:16)[1]

We love because he first loved us.
(1 John 4:19)[3]

Love comes from God.
(1 John 4:10)[2]

The LORD is faithful to all his promises and loving toward all he has made.
(Psalm 145:13)[4]

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is difficult to grasp how great and how vast God's love is for us.[5] His love is unfailing,[6] priceless,[6] and everlasting.[7,8]

Because God's nature is love, He commands that we love Him; we are to love God with all our heart, soul, mind, and strength.[9] This is the first and greatest commandment.[10]

If we love God, He promises to watch over us, love us, and protect us.[11,12] God loves those who love Him;[13] if we seek after Him, He promises that we will find Him.[13] If our lives give evidence of love,

For great is your love, reaching to the heavens;
your faithfulness reaches to the skies.
(Psalm 57:10)[5]

How priceless is your unfailing love!
(Psalm 36:7)[6]

I [the LORD] have loved you with an
everlasting love.
(Jeremiah 31:3)[7]

Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good;
his love endures forever.
(1 Chronicles 16:34)[8]

Love the LORD your God with all your heart and
with all your soul and with all your strength.
(Deuteronomy 6:5)[9]

"Teacher, which is the greatest commandment in the Law?"
Jesus replied: " *'Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.'*"
(Matthew 22:36-37)[10]

The LORD watches over all who love him,
but all the wicked he will destroy.
(Psalm 145:20)[11]

Spread your protection over them, that those who love
your name may rejoice in you.
(Psalm 5:11)[12]

I love those who love me,
and those who seek me find me.
(Proverbs 8:17)[13]

then this is proof that we know God.[14] However, if our lives do not show love, then this is evidence that we do not know God.[15]

God demonstrated his unsurpassing love for mankind by sending His only Son, Jesus Christ, to die for our sins.[16,17] In turn, Christ showed his love for mankind by being obedient to God's will and accepting death on a cross—even though He was innocent and committed no sin.[18] This outpouring of love is further completed when we, in turn, show our love for God by loving Jesus[19] and following His commands.[20,21]

Given God's emphasis on love, it is not surprising that Jesus proclaimed that the second greatest commandment ever given was to

Everyone who loves has been born of God
and knows God.
(1 John 4:7)[14]

Whoever does not love does not know God,
because God is love.
(1 John 4:8)[15]

This is love: not that we loved God, but that he loved us and
sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins.
(1 John 4:10)[16]

For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son,
that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life.
(John 3:16)[17]

He suffered death, so that by the grace of God
he might taste death for everyone.
(Hebrews 2:9)[18]

He who loves me [Jesus] will be loved by my Father,
and I too will love him and show myself to him.
(John 14:21)[19]

If you love me [Jesus] you will obey what I command.
(John 14:15)[20]

Whoever has my commands and obeys them,
he is the one who loves me.
(John 14:21)[21]

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"love your neighbor as yourself."[22] This means that Christ wants us to love one another, just as He loved us.[23] In the same manner, we are to treat others just as we would like to be treated.[24]

Our love for others is to be genuine; we are to love one another "deeply, from the heart."[25] When we do this, it is evidence that God lives in us and His love has been made complete in us.[26]

People will know that we are Christ's disciples when we show love to one another.[27] We show our love for Jesus by serving others.[28] If we say that we love God but hate our fellow man, then the Bible says we are liars.[29] Anyone who does not love his brother, whom

The second [greatest commandment] is this:
"Love your neighbor as yourself."
There is no commandment greater than these.
(Mark 12:31)[22]

My command is this: Love each other as I have loved you.
(John 15:12)[23]

So in everything, do to others what you would have them do to you, for this sums up the Law of the Prophets.
(Matthew 7:12)[24]

Love one another deeply, from the heart.
(1 Peter 1:22)[25]

No one has ever seen God; but if we love one another,
God lives in us and his love is made complete in us.
(1 John 4:12)[26]

By this all men will know that you are my disciples,
if you love one another.
(John 13:35)[27]

Again Jesus said, *"Simon son of John, do you truly love me?"*
He answered, "Yes, Lord, you know that I love you."
Jesus said, *"Take care of my sheep."*
(John 21:16)[28]

If anyone says, "I love God," yet hates his brother, he is a liar.
For anyone who does not love his brother, whom he has seen,
cannot love God, whom he has not seen.
(1 John 4:20)[29]

he has seen, cannot love God, whom he has not seen.[29] Therefore, God gives us this command: whoever loves God must also love his brother.[30]

Our love for others is not to be limited to the people who "love us back." We are to love everyone, including our enemies and those who persecute us.[31]

Although we are to love all people, our love for others (including our parents or our children) should never surpass our love of Christ.[32] Moreover, our love for money should never be greater than our love for God.[33]

Above all, the greatest expression of our love for others would be to lay down our life for our friends.[34] This is exactly what Jesus did for all of mankind.[35]

And he has given us this command:
Whoever loves God must also love his brother.
(1 John 4:21)[30]

You have heard that it was said, "Love your neighbor and hate your enemy." But I tell you: Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, that you may be sons of your Father in heaven.
(Matthew 5:43)[31]

Anyone who loves his father or mother more than me is not worthy of me; anyone who loves his son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me; and anyone who does not take his cross and follow me is not worthy of me.
(Matthew 10:37-38)[32]

No one can serve two masters. Either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve both God and Money.
(Matthew 6:24)[33]

*Greater love has no one than this,
that he lay down his life for his friends.*
(John 15:13)[34]

I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.
(John 10:11)[35]

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In the final analysis, the Bible tells us that the only thing that really counts in this life is faith expressing itself through love.[37] No matter what, we are never to let go of love and faith; we are to write them on the "tablets of our hearts."[38] We are to be imitators of God and live a life of love.[39] We are to remain in Christ's love until he returns again to take us into paradise and eternal life.[40,41]

God's Guidance

God has commanded us to love one another, but how do we do this? The best description of love ever given is that written by the apostle Paul in his letter to the church at Corinth. As Christians, we should use these characteristics as a recipe for loving others.

Paul's Description of Love

(Based on: 1 Corinthians 13:4-8)

- **Love is patient.** Be patient with everyone,[42] bearing with one another in love.[43] A man's wisdom[44] and understanding[45] give him patience.

The only thing that counts
is faith expressing itself through love.
(Galatians 5:6)[37]

Let love and faithfulness never leave you; bind them around your neck, write them on the tablet of your heart.
(Proverbs 3:3)[38]

Be imitators of God, therefore, dearly loved children and live a life of love, just as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us as a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God.
(Ephesians 5:1-2)[39]

As the Father has loved me, so have I loved you.
Now remain in my love.
(John 15:9)[40]

Keep yourself in God's love as you wait for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ to bring you to eternal life.
(Jude 1:21)[41]

- **Love is kind.** Shower each other with kindness and compassion.[46] Be warmhearted, considerate, and sympathetic. Kindness is one of the "fruits of the Spirit" and evidence that we are Spirit-filled.[47]

- **Love does not envy.** Don't be jealous or envious of the blessings bestowed on other people,[48,49] or envious of other people's skills or talents.[50] A heart at peace gives life, but envy "rots the bones."[51]

And we urge you, brothers, warn those who are idle,
encourage the timid, help the weak, be patient with everyone.
(1 Thessalonians 5:14)[42]

Be patient, bearing with one another in love.
(Ephesians 4:2)[43]

A man's wisdom gives him patience;
it is to his glory to overlook an offense.
(Proverbs 19:11)[44]

A patient man has great understanding,
but a quick-tempered man displays folly.
(Proverbs 14:29)[45]

Be kind and compassionate to one another,
forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you.
(Ephesians 4:32)[46]

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience,
kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control.
(Galatians 5:22-23)[47]

You shall not set your desire on your neighbor's house or land,
his manservant or maidservant, his ox or donkey,
or anything that belongs to your neighbor.
(Deuteronomy 5:21)[48]

Do not be overawed when a man grows rich, when the splendor
of his house increases; for he will take nothing with him
when he dies, his splendor will not descend with him.
(Psalm 49:16-17)[49]

Therefore, rid yourselves of all malice and all deceit,
hypocrisy, envy, and slander of every kind.
(1 Peter 2:1)[50]

A heart at peace gives life to the body, but envy rots the bones.
(Proverbs 14:30)[51]

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- **Love does not boast.** Don't brag or boast about yourself to others. All such behavior is evil and does not encourage love.[52] Boast only about the Lord[53] and what he has done for you.[54]

- **Love is not proud.** Pride only breeds quarrels.[55] The Lord detests the proud of heart.[56] Honor one another above yourself[57,58] and clothe yourself with humility.[59]

- **Love is not rude**. Try to be polite, courteous, considerate,[60,61] and well-mannered. Don't be rude or crude. Let your gentleness be evident to all.[62]

You boast and brag. All such boasting is evil.
(James 4:16)[52]

Let him who boasts boast in the Lord.
(1 Corinthians 1:31)[53]

May I never boast except in the cross
of our Lord Jesus Christ.
(Galatians 6:14)[54]

Pride only breeds quarrels; but wisdom is found
in those who take advice.
(Proverbs 13:10)[55]

The LORD detests all the proud of heart. Be sure of this:
They will not go unpunished.
(Proverbs 16:5)[56]

Honor one another above yourselves.
(Romans 12:10)[57]

Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit,
but in humility consider others better than yourselves.
(Philippians 2:3)[58]

All of you, clothe yourselves with humility toward one another.
(1 Peter 5:5)[59]

But the wisdom that comes from heaven is first of all pure;
then peace-loving, considerate, submissive, full of mercy
and good fruit, impartial and sincere.
(James 3:17)[60]

- **Love is not self-seeking.** Don't focus on what you can get out of the relationship (what's in it for you), but focus on what you can *give* to the relationship. Self-seeking people can provoke God's wrath and anger.[63]

- **Love is not easily angered.** Try to stay calm, and don't be quickly provoked into anger.[64] Anger stirs up disagreements and fights, and a hot-tempered man commits many sins.[65] Make every effort to live at peace with everyone.[66]

- **Love keeps no record of wrongs.** Don't keep bringing up past hurts or offenses. Forgive one another, just as in Christ, God forgave you.[67] No matter how many times you are hurt, if the person repents, keep on forgiving.[68]

Husbands, in the same way be considerate as you live with your wives, and treat them with respect as the weaker partner and as heirs with you of the gracious gift of life, so that nothing will hinder your prayers.
(1 Peter 3:7)[61]

Let your gentleness be evident to all.
(Philippians 4:5)[62]

But for those who are self-seeking and who reject the truth and follow evil, there will be wrath and anger.
(Romans 2:8)[63]

Do not be quickly provoked in your spirit, for anger resides in the lap of fools.
(Ecclesiastes 7:9)[64]

An angry man stirs up dissension, and a hot-tempered one commits many sins.
(Proverbs 29:22)[65]

Make every effort to live in peace with all men and to be holy.
(Hebrews 12:14)[66]

Bear with each other and forgive whatever grievances you may have against one another. Forgive as the Lord forgave you.
(Colossians 3:13)[67]

Then Peter came to Jesus and asked, "Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother when he sins against me? Up to seven times?" Jesus answered, *I tell you, not seven times, but seventy-seven times.*
(Matthew 18:21-22)[68]

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- **Love does not delight in evil.** Don't take delight in hurting others, or being mean or abusive, or otherwise sinful. Turn from evil and do good instead.[69]

- **Love rejoices in the truth.** Don't tell lies[70]or deceive.[71] God detests those who tell lies, but delights in those who are truthful.[72]

- **Love always protects.** Protect others from harm and keep them safe, just as God protects those He loves.[73,74] He is a shield for all who take refuge in him.[75] Show your love for others by protecting them from harm.

- **Love always trusts.** Build trust in your relationships. Keep your word. Follow through. Be loving. Be reasonable and predictable. Don't lose control or be abusive or aggressive. Trust in God and do good.[76]

Turn from evil and do good;
then you will dwell in the land forever.
(Psalm 37:27)[69]

Keep falsehood and lies far from me.
(Proverbs 30:8)[70]

Do not lie. Do not deceive one another.
(Leviticus 19:11)[71]

The LORD detests lying lips,
but he delights in men who are truthful.
(Proverbs 12:22)[72]

The LORD is my strength and my shield;
my heart trusts in him, and I am helped.
(Psalm 28:7)[73]

"Because of the oppression of the weak and the groaning
of the needy, I will now arise," says the LORD.
"I will protect them from those who malign them."
(Psalm 12:5)[74]

He is a shield for all who take refuge in him.
(Psalm 18:30)[75]

Trust in the LORD and do good.
(Psalm 37:3)[76]

- **Love always hopes.** Don't give up hope, no matter what difficulties you may be having in your relationship.[77] Keep positive and optimistic.[78] God is a God of miracles; nothing is impossible with God.[79] If you feel hopeless, try putting your hope in God.[80]

- **Love always perseveres.** Be persistent in your love for others. Don't give up on them or be discouraged.

- **Love never fails.** Even though you may experience difficulties along the road, loving another person always succeeds in the end. Your efforts will always bear fruit. Do everything in love.[81]

As we set about loving one another, rest assured that no matter what happens in life, those who believe in God will never be alone and will never be separated from God's love. The apostle Paul etched these sentiments into the history of mankind with these incredible words of assurance from Romans 8:38-39:

"For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

Anyone who is among the living has hope.
(Ecclesiastes 9:4)[77]

Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think about such things.
(Philippians 4:8)[78]

For nothing is impossible with God.
(Luke 1:37)[79]

Find rest, O my soul, in God alone; my hope comes from him.
(Psalm 62:5)[80]

Do everything in love.
(1 Corinthians 16:14)[81]